

STAFF EDITION · TOUR LEADER & TEACHER COMPANION

YPRES 1914–1918

Master Expedition Handbook, On-Site Scripts, Timings & Logistics

TOUR STAFF & LEADERSHIP DIRECTORATE

Tour Leaders: Mr Ben Lovett (Head of History) & Mr James Garrett (The History Boys)

Accompanying Staff: Dr Kirkup & Mrs Lushey

Expedition Dates: Thursday 1st – Saturday 3rd October 2026

Base Camp: Peace Village Hostel, Mesen, Belgium

Tour Operators: Joint Educational Partnership (Meoncross & The History Boys)



The War Memorial at Holy Rood Church, Stubbington — Anchoring our school expedition to our local parish fallen.

TOUR LEADERS:

Mr Ben Lovett & Mr James Garrett

ACCOMPANYING STAFF:

Dr Kirkup & Mrs Lushey

SCHOOL BASE 24/7 EMERGENCY:

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MASTER EXPEDITION TIMETABLE & SALIENT MAP

Tour Leader Pacing, Coach Logistics & Strategic Route

FIELD ROUTE
13 Historic Stops



Strategic Overview of the Ypres Salient (1914–1918): Showing frontlines, allied arcs, and major battlefield sites.

TOUR LEADER OPERATIONAL SCHEDULE

DAY / TIME	LOCATION & ACTIVITY	TEACHER PACING & KEY DIRECTIVES
Day 1 • 06:15	Depart Meoncross School • Folkestone Le Shuttle	Register check; 06:30 coach departs; passports & customs; Eurotunnel transit; ETA Boezinge 13:15 CET.
Day 1 • 13:30	Stop 1: Essex Farm ADS & Canal Bank	Gather group at Bunker 4; read McCrae; guide pupils to Valentine Strudwick headstone (Plot I.U.8).
Day 1 • 14:45	Stop 2: Langemarck German Cemetery	Transition talk on German bereavement; gather at Kameradengrab; prompt Sorley poem reading.
Day 1 • 16:00	Stop 3: Hooge Crater Museum & Trenches	Mine crater warfare; crater rim observation; front line trench walk; inspect museum collection.
Day 1 • 18:00	Check-in: Peace Village Hostel, Mesen	Room allocation & key cards; 2-course group dinner at 18:30; evening seminar; 22:00 quiet hours.
Day 2 • 09:15	Stop 4: Vancouver Corner (Brooding Soldier)	Canadian stand; gas warfare overview; terrain vantage looking east towards Gravenstafel.
Day 2 • 10:15	Stop 5: Sanctuary Wood (Hill 62) Trenches	Original preserved British frontlines; mud terrain inspection; underground sap entrances.
Day 2 • 11:30	Stop 6: Tyne Cot Commonwealth Cemetery	Baker/Blomfield pillbox assembly; Binyon reading; direct pupils to Hampshire names on rear wall.
Day 2 • 13:00	Salient Supermarket Lunch Break	Supervised lunch break; purchase fresh picnic supplies; ensure all pupils stay in buddy pairs.
Day 2 • 14:15	Stop 7: Lijssenthoek Military Cemetery	Casualty clearing station evacuation chain; timeline wall; headstone of Staff Nurse Nellie Spindler.
Day 2 • 15:45	Stop 8: Passchendaele Museum (Zonnebeke)	Underground dugout immersion (20ft subterranean bunks & dressing station); Chateau park trenches.
Day 2 • 20:00	Stop 9: The Menin Gate Last Post Ceremony	Arrive Ypres by 19:15 for prime position; brief Meoncross wreath bearers; Frank Rogers on Panel 35.
Day 3 • 09:15	Stop 10: Menin Gate Daylight & Ramparts Walk	Daylight panel study without crowds; Ramparts Cemetery walk; read Sassoon's anti-monument poem.
Day 3 • 10:30	Stop 11: De Groote's Chocolatier (Grote Markt)	Supervised confectionery visit; €30–€40 cash envelopes; discuss Ypres stone-by-stone rebirth.
Day 3 • 11:20	Stop 12: Talbot House (Toc H), Poperinge	Tea in soldiers' club; upper room hop-loft chapel; Tubby Clayton's radical egalitarian refuge.
Day 3 • 13:30	Stop 13: Poperinge Town Hall Death Cells	Cramped cells & execution post; British military discipline; shell shock & 2006 statutory pardon.
Day 3 • 14:30	Depart Poperinge • Calais Eurotunnel • Return	Coach departs 14:30; final head count; Eurotunnel customs; ETA Meoncross approx. 20:00–20:30.

STAFF SUPERVISORY PROTOCOL

Pupil count required at every coach departure and cemetery entrance. Dr Kirkup and Mrs Lushey lead sweep duties. In case of separation, designated pupil assembly point is the coach parking bay.

🔪 TOUR LEADER TALKING POINTS: THE LOWRY BROTHERS

Local Connection: Three sons of William and Annie Lowry of Manor Way Grange in Lee-on-the-Solent attended Stubbington House School. All three held commissions, and all three were killed in action across different theatres: Gallipoli (William), the Somme (Cyril), and Arras (Eric).

Pedagogical Goal: Connect grand tactical operations to individual boys who walked our local paths. Emphasise that William and Cyril have no known graves, while Eric lies in a marked grave at La Targette British Cemetery near Arras. Grieving father William Lowry built the Lowry Memorial Hall in Lee-on-the-Solent in their honour.



Lieut. William Lowry

8th Gurkha Rifles (Indian Army)

Eldest brother (aged 25); Cambridge scholar. Killed 4 June 1915 leading charge up Gully Ravine, Gallipoli, under heavy machine-gun fire.

Body never recovered. Commemorated on Helles Memorial, Turkey.

📍 **Helles Memorial, Gallipoli**



Capt. Cyril Lowry

2nd Bn, West Yorkshire Regt

Youngest brother (aged 20). Served under older brother Eric. Killed 25 March 1918 defending Somme crossing at Eterpigny during German Spring Offensive.

Fell in full view of Eric; body lost in withdrawal. Commemorated on Pozières Memorial.

📍 **Pozières Memorial, Somme**



Lt. Col. Eric Lowry

2nd Bn, West Yorkshire Regt (DSO, MC)

Middle brother (aged 25). Commanded 2nd West Yorkshires at Westhoek Ridge and Somme. Awarded DSO, MC & Bar, French Croix de Guerre.

Killed 23 September 1918 by machine gun inspecting outposts near Arleux, dying in his runner's arms. Buried at La Targette.

📍 **La Targette British Cemetery (Plot I. C. 2)**

🌀 Staff Action Points at Tyne Cot

1. Lead pupils along the central avenue directly to the Cross of Sacrifice built atop the captured German pillbox.
2. Guide students along the rear memorial wall to locate our parish fallen (such as L/Cpl Arthur Newman, Royal Engineers).
3. Emphasise how the tragedy of the three Lowry brothers mirrors the universal bereavement that affected families across every street in Britain.

THE SIX VILLAGE FALLEN & BOY SOLDIERS

Staff Plot Guides & Case Study: Private Valentine Strudwick

STUBBINGTON FALLEN

Holy Rood Parish

The Holy Rood Memorial Roll

SOLDIER	REGIMENT / UNIT	SALIENT LOCATION
Pte. Walter Spratt	1st Bn, Hampshire Regt	Ploegsteert (Missing)
Sgt. Frank Rogers	2nd Bn, Hampshire Regt	Menin Gate (Panel 35)
L/Cpl. Arthur Newman	Royal Engineers (Signals)	Tyne Cot Memorial
Pte. George Stares	8th Bn, Hampshire Regt	Bedford House Cemetery
Dvr. Edward Vear	Royal Field Artillery	Brandhoek Military Cemetery
Cpl. Harry Freemantle	Royal Marine Artillery	Dunkirk / Ypres Coast



The Memorial Tablet inside Holy Rood Church, Stubbington.

Staff Note: Distribute local fallen cards to student pairs during coach journey from Boezinge. Each pair will locate their assigned soldier's panel on site.

TOUR LEADER TALKING POINTS: BOY SOLDIER VALENTINE STRUDWICK

Location: Essex Farm Cemetery, Plot I. U. 8 (facing canal bank).

The Story: Enlisted at 14 claiming he was 19; killed in action on 14 January 1916 aged 15 years and 11 months.

Teaching Cue: Ask students to stand around the grave. Compare Valentine's age to their own year group. Note the continuous flow of poppy tributes laid by visiting schools from across Britain.

Mother's Epitaph: "Not Gone From Memory, Not Gone From Love, But Gone To Our Father's Home Above."

Use this epitaph to discuss the profound human cost borne by working-class families who lost adolescent boys before they had ever reached adult life.



CWGC Portland Stone Headstone Dimensions: 81cm x 38cm x 7.5cm.

TOUR LEADER BRIEFING: HEADSTONE ANATOMY

1. **Badge:** Regimental heraldry; equality across officer and private.
2. **Text:** Service number, rank, name, honours, regiment.
3. **Cross / Emblem:** Latin Cross, Star of David, or left blank.
4. **Age & Date:** Average age in the Salient was 24.
5. **Personal Inscription:** Family-paid line (max 66 characters).
Highlight to pupils how diverse these are: religious, stoic, or heartbroken.

Unknowns: Kipling's phrase: "A Soldier of the Great War — Known Unto God."

TOUR LEADER SCRIPT: TOPOGRAPHY OF THE SALIENT

The Ridge: Stand with students looking east from Ypres. The land rises barely 45 metres towards Passchendaele, but in flat Flanders, that low ridge commanded complete artillery domination.

Converging Arcs: German batteries positioned along the arc could shell British rear areas from three directions. Reinforcements had to march into the bulge under continuous observation.

STAFF MANAGEMENT AT CEMETERIES

Remind students that these are active cemeteries. No running, no sitting on headstones, no shouting. Set a calm, contemplative tone upon disembarking the coach.

🔪 STOP 1 TOUR SCRIPT: ESSEX FARM ADS

Where We Stand: Concrete bunkers built into the Yser canal bank. An Advanced Dressing Station where Canadian surgeons triaged thousands during Second Ypres.

Alexis Helmer: On 2 May 1915, McCrae's 22-year-old friend was blown to pieces by an 8-inch shell. McCrae performed the burial by lantern light; next morning he sat on the ambulance step and composed *In Flanders Fields*.



Concrete dressing station bunkers dug into the canal embankment.

🔪 STOP 2 TOUR SCRIPT: YORKSHIRE TRENCH

Discovery: Unearthed in 1992 by amateur archaeologists ("The Diggers") in an industrial zone.

What to Notice: The wooden A-frames, fire-bays, deep dugout entrance (holding 200 men), and the shallow water table.

In Flanders Fields

Lt. Col. John McCrae (1872–1918) • Canadian AMC



*In Flanders fields the poppies blow
Between the crosses, row on row,
That mark our place; and in the sky
The larks, still bravely singing, fly
Scarce heard amid the guns below.
We are the Dead. Short days ago
We lived, felt dawn, saw sunset glow,
Loved and were loved, and now we lie,
In Flanders fields.*

🎯 TEACHER FIELD TASK AT ESSEX FARM

Prompt a designated student to read stanzas 1 and 2 of *In Flanders Fields* standing directly outside Bunker 4. Then lead the group to Plot I. U. 8 to observe Valentine Strudwick's headstone.

🔪 STOP 3 TOUR SCRIPT: LANGEMARCK & THE STUDENT MYTH

The Myth of Langemarck: In November 1914, German propaganda claimed raw student regiments charged singing "*Deutschland über alles*". In reality, poorly trained youths were mown down by experienced British rifle fire.

Kameradengrab (Comrades' Grave): 24,917 men buried in a single mass grave behind the oak gatehouse.

Contrast with CWGC: Dark German granite, low flat markers, somber oak canopy—capturing defeat, national mourning, and heavy grief compared to British radiant Portland stone.

When You See Millions of the Mouthless Dead

Charles Sorley (1895–1915) • Capt., 7th Suffolks



*When you see millions of the mouthless dead
Across your dreams in pale battalions go,
Say not soft things as other men have said,
That you'll remember. For you need not so.
Give them not praise. For, deaf, how should they know
It is not curses heaped on each gashed head?
Nor tears. Their blind eyes see not your tears flow.
Nor honour. It is easy to be dead.*

Pedagogical Cue: Emil Krieger Statues

Gather students at the rear boundary facing Emil Krieger's four mourning bronze figures. Note how they huddle together without martial glory or triumphalism.

Key Question: Why did the German state choose dark basalt over white limestone?

LOGISTICAL TRANSFER TO MESEN

Depart Langemarck at 17:30. Coach journey south to Peace Village Hostel in Mesen takes approx. 35 mins. Prepare pupils for room check-in and evening meal.

DAY 2 FIELD STUDY • GAS WARFARE & UNDERGROUND MINES

Stops 4 & 5 • Vancouver Corner & Hooze Crater • Tour Scripts

MENIN ROAD
Gas & Mine Warfare

STOP 4 TOUR SCRIPT: VANCOUVER CORNER

22 April 1915: The first lethal use of poison gas in history. 168 tons of chlorine released by German forces against French Algerian troops.

The Canadian Stand: Canadian troops held the gap for days by urinating on handkerchiefs to neutralise chlorine. Commemorated by the magnificent *Brooding Soldier* monument.

STOP 5 TOUR SCRIPT: HOOGE CRATER

Underground War: Tunnelling companies dug deep into blue Flemish clay to detonate ammonal charges beneath German trenches.

The Hooze Crater: Detonated on 19 July 1915 (1,700lb ammonal), creating a 120ft wide crater. First German flamethrower attack occurred here 11 days later.

Break of Day in the Trenches

Isaac Rosenberg (1890–1918) • Private, King's Own



*The darkness crumbles away.
It is the same old druid Time as ever,
Only a live thing leaps on my hand,
A queer, sardonic rat,
As I pull the parapet's poppy
To stick behind my ear.
Droll rat, they would shoot you if they knew
Your cosmopolitan sympathies...*



Hooze Crater site: Preserved mine craters and trench warfare lines.

LUNCH BREAK DIRECTIVES AT HOOGE

Eat packed lunches at the Hooze Crater Museum picnic area. Restroom break. Coach boards at 13:00 sharp for Tyne Cot Cemetery.

STOP 6 TOUR SCRIPT: THE SCALE OF TYNE COT

The Scale: Largest British war cemetery in the world. 11,961 burials (8,369 unidentified). Sir Herbert Baker built the Cross of Sacrifice directly atop a captured German machine gun bunker.

The Memorial Wall: 34,984 names of soldiers missing after 16 August 1917.

Pilgrimage: Guide pupils to Hampshire Regiment panels and our parish fallen (including L/Cpl Arthur Newman on the Memorial Wall).



Cross of Sacrifice standing atop captured German bunker.

For the Fallen

Laurence Binyon (1869–1943) • British Museum



*With proud thanksgiving, a mother for her children,
England mourns for her dead across the sea...*

*They shall grow not old, as we that are left grow old:
Age shall not weary them, nor the years condemn.
At the going down of the sun and in the morning
We will remember them.*

Staff Coordination: Parish Fallen

After Binyon recitation at the Cross of Sacrifice, lead pupils to the Memorial Wall to locate our parish fallen (including L/Cpl Arthur Newman, Royal Engineers). Lay the Meoncross remembrance marker.

Allow 25 mins personal reflective walk across the rows.

NEXT STOP: RAMPARTS CEMETERY & MENIN GATE

Board coach at 15:45. Drive to Ypres Lille Gate for Stop 7 (Ramparts Cemetery) and prepare for evening Last Post Ceremony at Menin Gate.

🔪 STOP 8 TOUR SCRIPT: THE MENIN GATE

54,395 Names: Inscribed with soldiers missing in the Salient prior to 16 August 1917. Designed by Sir Reginald Blomfield.

The Last Post Ceremony: Held every night at 20:00 without fail (except during WWII occupation). Buglers of the volunteer fire brigade sound the salute.



The Menin Gate Memorial: Inaugurated July 1927.

On Passing the New Menin Gate

Siegfried Sassoon (1886–1967) • Capt., Royal Welch Fusiliers



*Who will remember, passing through this Gate?
The unheroic Dead who fed the guns?
Who shall absolve the foulness of their fate,—
Those doomed, conscripted, unvictorious ones?...
Well might the Dead who struggled in the slime
Rise and deride this sepulchre of crime.*

Staff Wreath-Laying Protocol

19:30: Secure prime position on northern walkway under the arch.

19:50: Designated Meoncross wreath bearers escorted by staff to ceremonial marshalling area.

20:00: Last Post sounded; two-minute silence; official wreath laying.

Staff Lead: Mr Ben Lovett & Mr James Garrett

EVENING RETURN TO PEACE VILLAGE

Depart Menin Gate at 20:45. Arrive hostel 21:15. Evening drinks/cookies. Curfew and phone collection in corridor at 22:00 sharp.



The Cloth Hall, Ypres (1919): Watercolour by Scottish war artist **Emily Murray Paterson RSW (1855–1934)**, painted on-site amidst the ruins after the Armistice (Imperial War Museum collection).

🔑 STOP 9 TOUR SCRIPT: THE REBIRTH OF YPRES

Total Destruction: By 1918, Ypres was rubble; Winston Churchill wanted the ruins left untouched as a sacred memorial. Instead, citizens rebuilt stone-for-stone.

The Lakenhalle: Built in 1304; rebuilt over 40 years. Inside is the *In Flanders Fields Museum*.



Talbot House Façade, Poperinge: The exterior façade on Gasthuisstraat, opened in December 1915 by Rev. Philip 'Tubby' Clayton as an unranked sanctuary for all soldiers behind the lines.

🔑 STOP 10 TOUR SCRIPT: TALBOT HOUSE (TOC H)

The Haven Behind the Lines: In Dec 1915, Army Chaplain Rev. Philip 'Tubby' Clayton opened this house in Poperinge as an alternative to pubs and brothels.

"All rank abandon ye who enter here": Officers and privates drank tea from the same mugs and played the same piano.

The Upper Room: Climb the creaking stairs to the hop-loft chapel. A carpenter's bench served as the altar.

The Soldier

Rupert Brooke (1887–1915) · Sub-Lieutenant, Royal Naval Division

*If I should die, think only this of me:
That there's some corner of a foreign field
That is for ever England. There shall be
In that rich earth a richer dust concealed;
A dust whom England bore, shaped, made aware,
Gave, once, her flowers to love, her ways to roam;
A body of England's, breathing English air,
Washed by the rivers, blest by suns of home.*



Trench & Military Terminology

ADS	Advanced Dressing Station: Frontline medical bunker behind trenches for urgent triage before casualty evacuation.
A-Frames	A-shaped timber frames supporting duckboard walkways above waterlogged trench mud.
Pillbox	Reinforced concrete machine gun bunker built by German forces to withstand heavy artillery shellfire.
Salient	A bulge in military lines surrounded by the enemy on three sides, exposed to converging artillery arcs.
Sump	A deep drainage pit dug beneath trench duckboards to catch pooling rainwater.
Trench Foot	Severe fungal and circulatory condition caused by prolonged immersion in cold, wet mud.

CWGC & Memorial Terminology

CWGC	Commonwealth War Graves Commission: Founded 1917 by Fabian Ware to care for 1.7 million fallen.
Cross of Sacrifice	Designed by Sir Reginald Blomfield: Portland stone cross bearing a bronze broadsword.
Stone of Memory	Designed by Sir Edwin Lutyens: altar-like stone carved with Kipling's phrase <i>"Their Name Liveth For Evermore"</i> .
Kameradengrab	German 'Comrades' Grave': a central mass burial holding thousands of fallen soldiers (e.g. 24,917 at Langemarck).
Portland Stone	Fine white limestone from Dorset, chosen for its luminosity and radical equality across all military ranks.

USEFUL FLEMISH & FRENCH TOPONYMS IN THE SALIENT

- Ieper:** Flemish name for Ypres.
- Poperinge:** Town behind lines known affectionately to British troops as *"Pop"*.
- Heuvelland:** 'Hill Country' south of Ypres (home of our Peace Village Hostel base in Mesen).
- Lakenhalle:** The medieval Cloth Hall in the Grote Markt of Ypres.
- Menenpoort:** Flemish for the Menin Gate.

CODE OF CONDUCT & EXPEDITION STANDARDS

- Quiet Respect:** Cemeteries are active places of mourning. Walk strictly on grass paths; do not sit on headstones or climb on memorial panels.
- Mobile Phone Protocol:** Phones may be used for photographs during the day. Collected each evening in dedicated staff bags at curfew.
- Hostel Downtime:** Quiet hours from 22:00 in Peace Village corridors. Respect international guests and staff sleep cycles.
- The Mission:** Always remember that we represent Meoncross School and our village parish of Holy Rood before the people of Belgium.

Expedition Staff: Mr Ben Lovett & Mr James Garrett (Tour Leaders) · Dr Kirkup & Mrs Lushey (Accompanying School Base 24/7 Emergency: **+44 (0)1329 288339** Staff)